



The Refund Racket

For a refunder in the 1980s, the old adage “you can never be too rich or too thin” could easily have included “or have too many qualifiers.” Can there ever be too much of a good thing? In an October 1987 *Atlantic Journal and Atlantic Constitution* article about refunds, Dr. Sam Dietz, professor of educational psychology at Georgia State University, was quoted as saying, “Receiving refunds in the mail acts as a positive reinforcement, so refunding may be a compulsive behavior.”

As a stay-at-home mom in the late 1980s and early 1990s, I was hooked on free stuff. The only adults I interacted with on a consistent basis were the UPS driver and the postal delivery worker. Boxes of company premiums arrived on my porch at least once a week, and my mailbox was full of samples, free coupons, and advertising T-shirts in sealed plastic bags. Walks with my children included forays into alleys where we collected proofs of purchase from other people’s garbage. A trip to the park meant dipping into the trash cans for stray candy bar wrappers. Weekly, and yes, sometimes even daily trips to the recycling center were a form of entertainment my older children grew up with. Who needs nights at the movies or theme parks when there are open recycling bins just ten blocks from home?